

ALBATROSSES, PETRELS, AND SHEARWATERS

Long-winged albatrosses and their relatives spend much of their lives in the air, travelling great distances as they scan the surface of the oceans for fish.

These birds, the order Procellariiformes, are master aeronauts, rarely returning to land except to breed. Albatrosses, petrels, and shearwaters – called “tubenoses” on account of the tubular nasal protuberances on their bill – are globally widespread, ocean-going birds, but show greatest diversity in the southern hemisphere.

Unusually for birds, they locate their sparsely scattered sea prey by smell. All but the smallest diving species in this group have elongated wings, and almost all have their webbed feet positioned so far back that some cannot easily walk. These

birds deter predators by regurgitating a noxious oil that they produce in their stomach and sometimes forcefully eject. This oil is also nutritious enough to feed their chicks.

SLOW REPRODUCTION

Tubenoses form pair bonds, sometimes for life, which in the larger species can be several decades. Many species breed in colonies on remote islands, often returning to the same site year after year. Smaller species nest in cavities and burrows. These birds have low breeding rates, but the parents invest heavily in rearing their young. Typically, tubenoses make only one breeding attempt per season and produce a single egg. Despite a lengthy incubation period, chicks are helpless upon hatching and mature very slowly.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	PROCELLARIIFORMES
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	147



Long-lived wandering albatrosses are monogamous. They reinforce their pair-bonding with an elaborate courtship dance.

WANDERING ALBATROSS

Diomedea exulans

F: Diomedidae

The largest of the giant Southern Ocean *Diomedea* albatrosses, this bird forms a life-long pair bond and produces a single young every two years.

dark wings
turn white
with age

1.1–1.4 m
3½–4½ ft

mostly white body

pale pink bill

LAYSAN ALBATROSS

Phoebastria immutabilis

F: Diomedidae

Albatrosses from the northern Pacific include those that breed in the tropics, like this small species that nests on islands – including Hawaii – when breeding.

77–80 cm
30–32 in

BLACK-FOOTED ALBATROSS

Phoebastria nigripes

F: Diomedidae

Like other northern Pacific albatrosses, this small, dark species frequently interrupts its gliding flight with bursts of wing-flapping.

68–74 cm
27–29 in

black “brow”

BLACK-BROWED ALBATROSS

Thalassarche melanophrys

F: Diomedidae

This is one of several dark-backed albatrosses called mollymawks, from the southern hemisphere. It nests in dense colonies, producing one egg each year.

80–95 cm
32–37 in

NORTHERN FULMAR

Fulmarus glacialis

F: Procellariidae

This gull-like petrel is common throughout the northern hemisphere. It nests on cliffs and can eject a foul-smelling stomach oil to repel predators.

45–50 cm
18–20 in

